

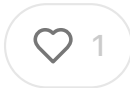
A mismatch between P and the first 2 paragraphs of the Introduction

This post is about a problem that arises in building the first part of the Introduction



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APR 19, 2023



For those of you familiar with the **RAP** method, this post is about a problem that arises when we set out to build the Introduction. Specifically, it is about a mismatch between the logic of **P** and the first few paragraphs of the Introduction.

If you are not yet familiar with the **RAP** method, [this textbook](#) lays it out and [this course](#) walks you through the process of building a paper using the method.

First, a quick refresher on how **P** is used to build Part 1 of the Intro

Remember that **P**, the positioning statement, is used to build the first couple of paragraphs of the Introduction, which we call Part 1 of the Introduction. The purpose of Part 1 of the Introduction is to make space for the paper. And that is exactly what **P** does: it makes space for **R**, the research question, and therefore the paper. Which is why **P** is used to build Part 1 of the Introduction.

The mechanics of building the first couple of paragraphs from **P** are simple. We break **P** into its component claims. There are usually two of these and they contrast (explicitly or implicitly). The claims are then fleshed out into a (short) paragraph each. And the contrast arising from the juxtaposition provokes **R**.

In this way, a single sentence – **P** – is built out into a couple of crisp paragraphs that help readers step into your world and see why it makes sense to pose your p

In other words, these paragraphs help readers begin to appreciate the contribution your paper makes to the literature.

The mismatch and its consequence

Although the process of building two short paras from P is fairly mechanical, something unpredictable can happen along the way.

And the result is that the first two paragraphs of the Introduction do not match the clean, *inevitable* logic of P. Instead, they are loosely written, include irrelevant details, make weak points, or seem unrelated to one another.

In such cases, we might see three or four meandering paragraphs at the top of the Introduction, an occurrence that is sure to test the kindest reader's patience. The paragraphs might be crammed with details that will eventually become relevant, but that right now are overwhelming. Or the main idea of each component of P might be unstated or be buried in a paragraph instead of being front and center in its sentence. Or the terminology of the first few paragraphs may be different from the terminology of P, which usually means that the meaning of these paragraphs is subtly different from the meaning of P.

A consequence of all this is that the tension in P that makes space for the point does not translate to the first few paragraphs of the Introduction, where it is needed most. Which means that even after having read six score and more words, readers do not know why the paper is being written; in turn, this means that they are not placed to appreciate its contribution to the literature.

An example of the mismatch

So far, we have talked about the mismatch between P and Part 1 of the Introduction. No specifics. So, here is a quick example.

First, here is the RAP the writer came up with.

P: The workhorse model of X does not square with the facts.

R: What is a model of X that does square with the facts?

A: I propose a model in which....

Now, to build Part 1 of the Intro, we would break P into its two component doing this we lay bare the central tension that makes space for the paper:

P⁺: There is a workhorse model of X

P⁻: It does not square with the facts.

Then, we would flesh each claim out into a paragraph.

PARA 1 will flesh out "There is a workhorse model of X". It could describe the model in a sentence. Then, to back up the claim that this is the "workhorse model of X," it could cite papers that use the model to study X. These citations suggest the relevance/importance of the research question that readers are beginning to guess is coming.

PARA 2 will flesh out "But it does not square with the facts." To do so, it will highlight the facts (at least the most important one or two) and explain how they are at odds with the workhorse model. This paragraph furthers the reader's understanding of the relevance/importance of the research question that is now quite sure is coming.

By Para 3, we are ready to transition into Part 2 of the Intro with a sentence like "This paper therefore proposes a model..."

Yet, the actual paragraphs the reader sees go something like this:

PARA 1: The workhorse model of X is ABC. This model features A, B, and C.

also features D. It has E, F and G.

PARA 2: Policymakers think about J. But J is not easy to elicit for three reasons. The first is K. The second is L. the third is M.

PARA 3: M is at odds with B. And B occurs in the workhorse model due to the underlying assumption A1.

Why a mismatch arises

Let us talk about why a mismatch between P and the first few paragraphs of the Introduction might arise.

The simplest explanation is that the writer forgot they had written a good P and they have deliberately set it aside and built the Intro in a stream-of-consciousness writing style. What a waste of effort! We refine P to a sharp point exactly *because* we want to get to the point. For many things, including building the first two paragraphs of the Introduction. Without P as a guide, a writer would have to have the essential logic of P etched in their brain that they would not become distracted by details that interest them but be irrelevant for readers. And, in my experience, it is rare that a writer writing first drafts to be in such a position – mostly, we are all still working on P. We write and rewrite the first several drafts.

Another explanation for the mismatch is that the logic of P isn't quite right. As the writer works to flesh out its components, they realize either that something was left out or that something does not quite hold up. When they realize this, they try to weave in missing information or veer slightly from the part of P that does hold up. But if you do this while working with full paragraphs, the essential logic of P is captured in a single sentence when writing P is liable to get lost. In such cases, it would be better to first revise P and then build new paragraphs afresh from the revised P.

A third explanation is that in fleshing out the components of P, the writer has

lost in the details. When we draft P, we are looking at the paper from a distance; then, as we work to flesh out the details in each part of P, *other* details crop up that feel need to be explained right away. And so, the amount of information balance we lose the original thread of logic – and readers get dragged into this mess.

A final explanation I have observed over the years is fear: writers who have a good P suddenly get scared that it is not *enough*. They might suddenly remember the last time they presented their work, they faced a barrage of stressful questions. And so they may try to preemptively answer all those questions, having forgotten that (their implicit) P was different at the time (or that the questions came from a hostile audience member with a reputation for badgering speakers). Or a writer might remember an advisor's exhortations to "MAKE readers care" or "MAKE the paper sexier" – don't get me started on this latter piece of advice – and not knowing how to do this, begin panic-loading the first few paragraphs with grandiose yet self-referential and ultimately irrelevant details. Of course, what we write out of fear is usually not good.

To Do Now

If you happen to build papers using the RAP method, here is a quick checklist to ensure the good work you did in developing P translates over to Part 1 of the Introduction.

- Look at P
- Split it into its (usually two) component claims, and call them P^+ and P^-
- Now look at the first sentences of the first 2 paras in the Intro – do they state P^+ and P^- ?
 - If yes, congratulations!
 - If not, think about why. If it is because P isn't right to begin with, start from scratch: redraft P and then build new paras from it.